Concepts of gender as a spectrum predict linguistic judgments about singular they

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Background: Singular *they* is changing

English singular *they* is very old, but its use is recently expanding. Two kinds of singular *they* (Arnold, in press):

The old kind: Underspecified *They:* Discourse representations are underspecified.
The identity and/or gender of the referent is not known or not developed in the discourse. Examples: Everyone….they; A single mother…*they*; My neighbor…*they*; Liz…*they.* Use of *they* is optional.

The new kind: Personal *They:* Discourse representations are specified at least w.r.t. pronouns.
The referent's personal pronouns are they/them so other pronouns are impolite (Conrod, 2020). Use of *they* is not optional.

Acceptance of both forms is rising over time (Bjorkman, 2017; Konnelly & Cowper, 2020)
Singular *they* is more accepted by:
- younger speakers (Camilliere et al., 2021; Conrod, 2019)
- people with greater non-binary acceptance (Camilliere et al., 2021)

Research Question:

Does linguistic acceptance of singular *they* correspond to more spectrum-vs.-binary concepts of gender?
Rivas (2015) claims that "half of all millennials believe that gender is on a spectrum", but this paper is not available.
Measures of nonbinary/transgender acceptance are related but not uniquely about gender concepts. (Camilliere et al., 2020; Conrod et al., 2022; Gardner, 2023).

Question 1 (Methods): Can we validate an instrument for measuring individual differences in gender concepts?
Question 2 (Theory): Does increased acceptability of personal *they* correspond to stronger application of a politeness rule ("Use *they* when it's someone's personal pronoun") or a nonspecific increase in accepting singular *they*?

The Gender Concepts Questionnaire

Participants rate 30 statements in 5 theoretically-organized subsets about gender from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree). Half are reverse coded.
1. Self-determinability. Biological sex determines your gender. [reverse coded]
2. Nonbinary validity. People can be non-binary, genderqueer, or an identity other than male or female.
3. Mutability. For a given person, the gender they are today is always the same as it will be next year. [reverse coded]
4. Simultaneous fluidity. A person's gender can change depending on how they feel at the time.
5. Gender can include all or no gender. Some people identify with all gender categories.

The linguistic rating Questionnaire

Participants rate acceptability of "they". (Adapted from Camilliere et al. 2021).
Alex uses they/them pronouns; Liz uses she/her pronouns.

I left a voicemail for Alex and told them to call me back.
Liz should know their own phone number.
Alex said they would be coming late to dinner.
Liz gave themselves a haircut.
Liz texted me, but I didn't respond to them.
I hope Alex bought themselves a coffee.
Liz must have gotten ripped off when they signed up for health insurance.
I heard that Alex got a lot of presents for their birthday.

Thank you

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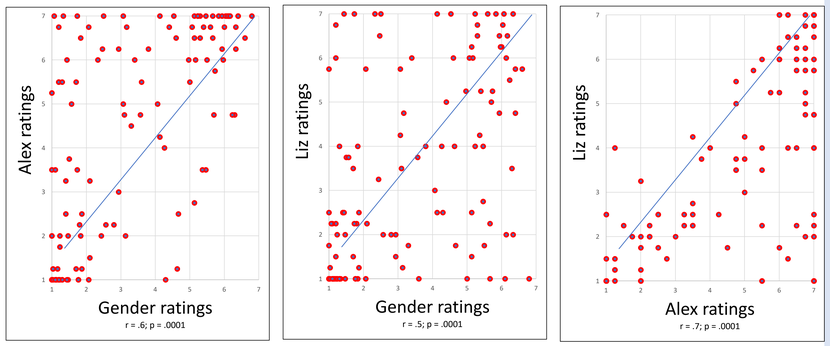
Methods

120 Prolific native speakers of English from the US
Pre-registered sample and methods
Qualtrics survey: 1) Concepts; 2) Linguistic judgments; 3) Background Questions (age, state of domicile; education; gender identity; race/ethnicity; familiarity with singular *they* (4 questions). Prolific profiles provided political orientation.

Results

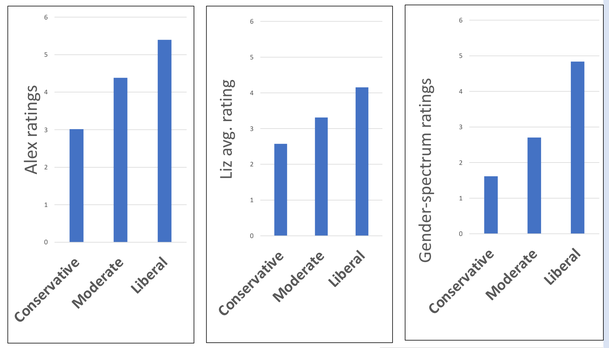
Question 1: Is the gender concepts questionnaire valid? YES

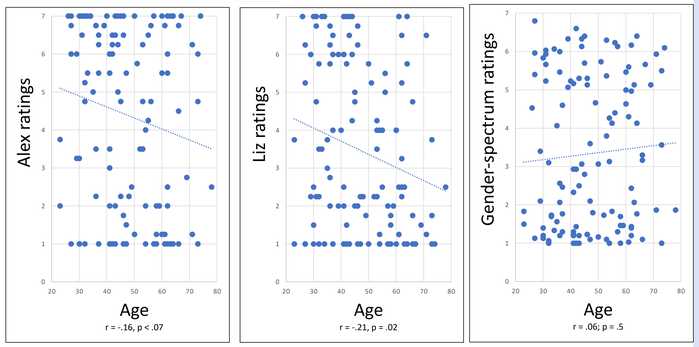
Concepts Questionnaire Validation
- EFA: One factor (SABIC = 11791), $r^2 > .5$ for all but six items.
- Ratings correlate across subscales (r's = .84 to .95).
- Gender and linguistic ratings correlate



Question 2: Does greater acceptability result in a stronger sensitivity to the politeness rule for personal *they* (greater differentiation between Alex and Liz) or a nonspecific shift?
→ Politeness rule applies: Alex-ratings are higher than Liz ratings
→ But acceptance for Alex and Liz highly correlates: nonspecific acceptance except for a small group

Exploratory demographics analysis:
Who accepts singular *they*?
- Liberal politics predicts acceptance of *they* for Alex (r=.45, p <.0001) and gender as a spectrum (r = .73, p < .0001)
- Familiarity with sg-*they predicts* acceptance of *they* for Alex (r=.45, p <.0001) and gender as a spectrum (r = .52, p < .0001)
- Liberal participants are more familiar with sg-*they*, but NOT younger nor more educated
- Gender-spectrum ratings are NOT higher for younger participants
- Younger age only WEAKLY predicts *they* acceptance for Alex (r = -.17, p = .06) and Liz (r= -.21, p = .02)
- Younger participants are more familiar with *they*
- 17 queer participants have higher familiarity with they but other correlations are underpowered





Conclusions

- We validated a tool for indexing gender concepts as binary vs. spectrum. Future goal: a shorter tool.
- Linguistic ratings shows that personal *they* (Alex) is more accepted than underspecified *they* (Liz), but acceptance of both increases with gender-spectrum concepts, younger age, and liberal political views. This suggests a broad linguistic grammatical change.